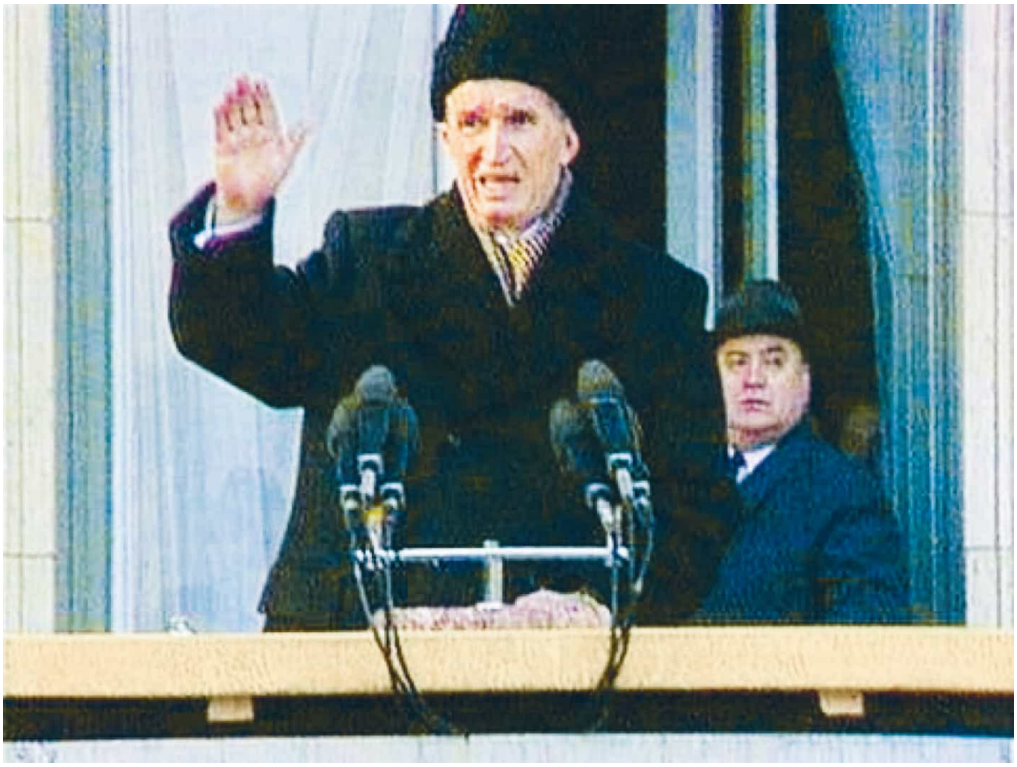


Credit 1.18

18. The moment a world collapses: a stunned Ceauşescu cannot believe his eyes and ears.

All this happened live on Romanian television, as three-quarters of the populace sat glued to the screens, their hearts throbbing wildly. The notorious secret police – the Securitate – immediately ordered the broadcast to be stopped, but the television crews disobeyed. The cameraman pointed the camera towards the sky so that viewers couldn't see the panic among the party leaders on the balcony, but the soundman kept recording, and the technicians continued the transmission. The whole of Romania heard the crowd booing, while Ceauşescu yelled, 'Hello! Hello! Hello!' as if the problem was with the microphone. His wife Elena began scolding the audience, 'Be quiet! Be quiet!' until Ceauşescu turned and yelled at her – still live on television – 'You be quiet!' Ceauşescu then appealed to the excited crowds in the square, imploring them, 'Comrades! Comrades! Be quiet, comrades!'

But the comrades were unwilling to be quiet. Communist Romania crumbled when 80,000 people in the Bucharest central square realised they were much stronger than the old man in the fur hat on the balcony. What is truly astounding, however, is not